

# Content Sourcing Strategy & Next Upgrades

What the field actually does to source footage, where our platform has gaps, plus the Phase 2 footage plan and a cost-benefit on the AI writer and voice. Prepared 6 July 2026; all facts & prices verified against live sources that day. Revised to reflect your new 32 GB Mac and a deeper scan of real faceless/automation operators.

THE 60-SECOND VERSION

- **Biggest realisation:** for true crime, the field's standard visual is **NOT stock video clips** — it's **still images (archival-style / AI) with a slow "Ken Burns" pan-and-zoom**, plus maps, documents and (the big one) **real public-records bodycam/dashcam footage**. If we only wire up Pexels clips, our videos will look like generic stock, not true crime.
- **Phase 2 should be a ladder, not one source:** AI image + pan/zoom (the backbone) → stock video (Pexels/Pixabay) → AI video generation (Veo/Kling) for shots that don't exist → and a **public-records footage pipeline** that no stock library can give us.
- **Real monetization risk to design around:** YouTube's **15 July 2025** policy update explicitly names "*true-crime AI-narrated stories with still images*" as the kind of mass-produced content it now demonetizes. Our defense is built-in **variation + a genuine editorial/commentary layer**, not just clean sourcing.
- **Voice (corrected for your new 32 GB Mac):** keep the free local **Kokoro** voice as the default — the memory risk that worried me is a non-issue at 32 GB. No need to pay for a cloud voice.
- **AI script writer:** still worth it — **Claude Sonnet 5**, ~1–2 cents per video.

## Part 1 · How the field actually sources content

Before deciding our Phase 2, here's what people running faceless / automated channels really do in 2025–2026 — the concrete playbook, not theory.

### The common stack

The canonical faceless pipeline is: AI script → AI voiceover (usually ElevenLabs) → footage matched to the script → auto-captions → upload. For footage, practitioners overwhelmingly name a short list: **Pexels, Pixabay, Mixkit, Videvo** (free) and **Storyblocks, Envato, Artgrid, Artlist, Motion Array** (paid). Notably, several creators report free Pexels B-roll *outperforming* paid stock — so starting free is well-supported.

**The 2025–26 shift is toward generating the shot instead of finding it:** AI video tools (**Google Veo 3, Kling, Runway, Sora, Luma**) and — most common for narration-heavy niches — **AI still images (Flux, DALL-E, Midjourney) with a Ken Burns pan/zoom**. Every serious all-in-one tool now bolts AI generation on top of licensed stock.

### What the all-in-one tools use under the hood

| TOOL                      | FOOTAGE SOURCING UNDER THE HOOD                                         | TARGETS                            |
|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Pictory / Visla / InVideo | License <b>Storyblocks + Getty</b> via partner APIs, plus AI generation | Explainer, listicle, blog-to-video |

| TOOL                                        | FOOTAGE SOURCING UNDER THE HOOD                                   | TARGETS                             |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|
| <b>AutoShorts.ai</b> (\$83K/mo in 6 months) | Stock + AI-generated visuals, auto-posted                         | Reddit stories, facts, motivational |
| <b>Revid.ai / Vadoo</b>                     | Stock library + AI media + image-to-video effects                 | General faceless shorts             |
| <b>Vexub</b>                                | AI images + <b>Veo 3</b> AI video + clipping; ~€1/video           | <b>True crime</b> , history, horror |
| <b>Opus / Klap / Submagic</b>               | No sourcing — they <b>repurpose your own long-form</b> into clips | Clipping/repurposing                |

Takeaway: serious tools = licensed stock (Storyblocks/Getty) + an AI-generation rung. The differentiator everyone's adding is AI generation, not a bigger stock library.

### The newest sourcing model: the "clipping economy"

A fast-growing model inverts sourcing entirely: rights-holders (creators, brands, streamers) **pay clippers per 1,000 views** via platforms like **Whop** and hand over the source footage themselves. Sourcing risk drops to zero because the owner is commissioning the clips. Worth noting as a clean, legal supply channel we could plug into later.

## Part 2 · Genre-specific sourcing — true crime & sports

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### True crime — what actually works

- **Visual backbone = stills + Ken Burns zoom**, not stock clips. Archival-style photos, maps, timelines, on-screen documents. AI-generated atmospheric establishing shots (foggy roads, empty lots) fill gaps "without copyright concerns."
- **Public-records footage is the field's highest-value source** — bodycam/dashcam obtained via public-records/FOIA requests, and footage already released on police/court portals. It's dramatic, real, and effectively copyright-free. Reference point: *Code Blue Cam* built **1B+ views** primarily on public-records footage.
- **Google Earth Studio flyovers** of real locations are a cheap, distinctive, "real" visual — a whole sub-genre uses them.
- **Story/facts** come from primary sources: court records (**PACER**, and the free **CourtListener/RECAP**), old newspapers (newspapers.com), plus **archive.org / Prelinger, NASA, Library of Congress** public-domain archives. Credible channels don't rely on Wikipedia.
- **Reused news footage** is common but the top fair-use / copyright-claim risk — best avoided.

#### THE MONETIZATION LANDMINE — DESIGN AROUND THIS

YouTube's **15 July 2025** "inauthentic content" update explicitly names "*true-crime AI-narrated stories with still images*" as targeted AI slop, and "Reused Content" rejections are very common for stock-plus-voiceover channels. The field's defense — and what we should bake into the pipeline — is **per-video visual/style variation** and a **genuine editorial/commentary layer**, not identical templates at high cadence. This dovetails with the legal-compliance engine already in our True Crime factory.

### Sports highlights — survival is strategy, not stealth

- **Enforcement differs by league, and that's the load-bearing fact: the NBA claims revenue (no strike)** — channels survive but unmonetized on those clips; **NFL and UFC strike/take down aggressively** and kill channels. Pick claim-tolerant leagues.
- **What survives:** genuinely **transformative** commentary/analysis/telestration over *short* windows; licensed access; and "**edits**" (music + effects) which do far better on TikTok/IG than raw highlights.
- **What reliably dies:** reposting raw broadcast clips — which is close to what a bare yt-dlp download produces. The **transformation layer is what changes the outcome**, not the download method.

### Part 3 · Gap analysis — what we're missing

We have yt-dlp windowed downloads (sports) and are about to add Pexels/Pixabay stock (true crime). Against the field, here's what's missing, in priority order.

- 1 Public-records footage pipeline (true crime)** — the highest-value untapped source. Bodycam/dashcam/court exhibits via records requests or already-released PD portals: real, dramatic, copyright-free. Nothing in stock APIs gives real case footage; this does.
- 2 AI image + Ken Burns as the true-crime backbone** — the genre is stills-with-motion, not stock video. Add an AI-image → pan/zoom stage or our output looks like generic B-roll.
- 3 An AI video-generation rung** (Veo 3 / Kling / Runway) for shots stock can't provide — the standard fallback every serious tool now has.
- 4 Google Earth Studio flyovers** of real case/game locations — cheap, real, distinctive.
- 5 Public-domain archives** (archive.org/Prelinger, NASA, LoC) — free, API-accessible, ideal for historical crime and lowest legal risk.
- 6 Primary-source story sourcing** — PACER / free CourtListener-RECAP + newspapers.com; court PDFs double as on-screen document visuals.
- 7 Sports: per-league strategy + a transformation layer** — pick claim-tolerant leagues and add commentary/analysis/edit treatment. Raw windowed downloads alone reproduce the struck pattern.
- 8 Anti-repetition variation** — randomized visual styles + a distinct editorial layer, as direct defense against the July-2025 crackdown.
- 9 The clipping-economy channel** (Whop-style) — an optional, legally clean supply where rights-holders hand us footage and pay per view.
- 10 Storyblocks-class licensed stock** — worth it later for breadth + Content-ID whitelisting; free Pexels/Pixabay is a fine start.

RECOMMENDED PHASE 2 = A FALLBACK LADDER, NOT ONE SOURCE

AI image + Ken Burns (backbone) → Pexels/Pixabay stock clips → AI video gen (Veo/Kling) for missing shots → local curated mood bank → placeholder as last resort. Plus, as a separate track for true crime, a public-records / public-domain footage ingest. This mirrors exactly what the field's best tools do.

### Part 4 · The Phase 2 footage sources, compared

| SOURCE  | FREE API?    | YOUTUBE + MONETIZE? | ATTRIBUTION? | VERTICAL?     | ROLE FOR US   |
|---------|--------------|---------------------|--------------|---------------|---------------|
| Pexels  | Free forever | Allowed             | Not required | Native filter | Primary stock |
| Pixabay | Free forever | Yes                 | Not required | Sort by size  | Backup stock  |

| SOURCE                     | FREE API? | YOUTUBE +<br>MONETIZE? | ATTRIBUTION? | VERTICAL?  | ROLE FOR US              |
|----------------------------|-----------|------------------------|--------------|------------|--------------------------|
| archive.org /<br>Prelinger | Free      | Public domain          | Not required | Crop       | Historical /<br>archival |
| Coverr                     | Free demo | Yes                    | Required     | Filterable | Optional 3rd pass        |
| Storyblocks / Getty        | Paid      | Yes (Content-ID safe)  | —            | Yes        | Later, at scale          |

**What you'd need to supply to start:** two free API keys — **Pexels** + **Pixabay** (~2-min signups, no card). AI image/video generation would each need one paid key when we get to those rungs.

## Part 5 · Quality boosts — cost-benefit

### Boost A — AI script writer (worth it)

Today's scripts use a built-in rules/template writer — factual but flat. An AI writer gives more vivid wording and tighter hooks. Cost assumes ~2,000 words in / 1,000 out per video.

| MODEL                                   | / VIDEO       | / 100 VIDEOS | FIT                                                             |
|-----------------------------------------|---------------|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Claude Haiku 4.5                        | \$0.007       | \$0.70       | Cheapest; built for simple tasks — flatter                      |
| <b>Claude Sonnet 5</b><br>(recommended) | \$0.014–0.021 | \$1.40–2.10  | The production-writing tier — best balance                      |
| Claude Opus 4.8                         | \$0.035       | \$3.50       | Barely dearer; strength is complex reasoning, not short scripts |

For comparison: OpenAI GPT-5.4-mini ≈ \$0.60/100, Gemini 3.5 Flash ≈ \$1.20/100 — all near-free.

**RECOMMENDATION**  
Turn it on with **Claude Sonnet 5** — ~\$1.40–\$3 total even at 100–150 videos/month. Needs one AI script key from you.

### Boost B — Voice (corrected for your new 32 GB Mac)

The good local voice, **Kokoro**, is free and open-source but runs in Docker. My *earlier* report advised moving to a cloud voice — but that was driven almost entirely by your old 8 GB Mac's crash risk (Kokoro's Docker wrapper has a memory-leak bug that could balloon to 20–30 GB). **On your new 32 GB machine that risk is a non-issue.**

| OPTION                                          | / 100 VIDEOS | NOTES (32 GB MACHINE)                                                 |
|-------------------------------------------------|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Kokoro (local, Docker)</b> (now recommended) | \$0          | Free, good quality, plenty of RAM headroom now — the sensible default |
| Google Cloud TTS — Neural2                      | \$0–\$1.36   | Fine optional backup; no local load, needs a key                      |
| ElevenLabs (Creator)                            | ~\$7.72+     | Best acting/emotion if you ever want premium narration                |

**RECOMMENDATION (REVISED)**  
Keep **Kokoro** as the default free local voice — just open Docker before rendering. No cloud voice needed for RAM reasons anymore. Consider ElevenLabs later only if you want premium emotional narration for true crime.

## Recommended next actions

- Phase 2 footage (biggest visible upgrade):** build the fallback ladder — start with AI-image+Ken-Burns + Pexels/Pixabay stock. You supply two free API keys; I build the matching + local mood bank.

- **True-crime realism + safety:** add a public-records / public-domain footage track, and bake in per-video variation to stay clear of the July-2025 crackdown.
- **Sports:** add a transformation layer (commentary/edit) and target claim-tolerant leagues — this matters more than the download method.
- **Sharper scripts:** add a Claude Sonnet 5 key; I wire the AI writer behind a toggle.
- **Voice:** just keep Kokoro (open Docker) — nothing to buy.

Suggested order: Phase 2 footage ladder first (biggest payoff), with the anti-repetition variation built in alongside; then the AI writer; sports transformation layer whenever you want to push that genre. Say the word on any one.

## Sources (verified 6 July 2026)

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- Kokoro / voice — [huggingface.co/hexgrad/Kokoro-82M](https://huggingface.co/hexgrad/Kokoro-82M) · [github.com/remsky/Kokoro-FastAPI](https://github.com/remsky/Kokoro-FastAPI) (issue #262)